decision to abduct Bhindranwale from Chowk Mehta was taken by the PM. Or the 1 Akbar Road group thought Bhindranwale's stature needed a further boost through a dramatic abduction. Or they wanted Bhindranwale to be suitably alerted that Chowk Mehta was no longer safe. That was perhaps the reason why an easily identifiable person like me was the first choice for the 'casing' operation. The job could easily have been done by someone else without being noticed, as it was later done by DGS R.T. Nagrani, to plan an SSF-led commando operation at the Golden Temple in April 1984.

For the 1 Akbar Road group, Bhindranwale's move to Guru Nanak Niwas had several advantages. First, Bhindranwale could carry out his extremist activities without any real threat of being arrested by the police. The Niwas, though not a part of the Golden Temple complex, provide a better cover, being an official guest house of the SGPC, where police would normally not enter without approval from the concerned Central government authorities, which was not that easy to get. Second, anything said or done by Bhindranwale or his followers on his behalf from the Niwas or the temple complex would attract greater attention in national and international media. Third, his presence at Guru Nanak Niwas was expected to build pressure on the moderate Akali leadership, led by Longowal, to keep the pot boiling in Punjab.

Planning 'Operation Sundown'

I met Ram Tekchand (R.T.) Nagrani, former DGS, at his Vasant Vihar residence on 16 April 2019, and a couple of times after that too, to seek his views on the SFF heliborne operation that had been planned by the directorate general of security. Born in 1928, Nagrani is over ninety years old now. He had a serious heart problem in November 2014 when he was hospitalized for six days. Though physically somewhat weak, he regularly went for morning walks and played bridge at Vasant Vihar Club in the afternoons. Fortunately for me, he still remembered crucial details of the planned SFF-led heliborne operation to abduct Bhindranwale from the Golden Temple complex in April 1984.